



The legendary American critic Gail Greene once cut through that moment with brutal clarity, calling this strain of cooking "brain effing with no orgasm." It was said half in jest, but with full intent.

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in the familiarity of something as blunt as McDonald's—not out of preference, but out of a need their previous meal did not fulfil.

We saw similar arcs elsewhere. Noma, under René Redzepi, redefined global fine dining with foraging and hyper-locality. It influenced a generation. And yet even Noma has had to confront the question of sustainability—not just ecological, but human, economic, and creative. When a restaurant becomes an idea larger than its own daily practice, it begins to strain under its own mythology.

More recently, restaurants like Ultraviolet in Shanghai or Alchemist in Copenhagen have pushed dining into immersive theatre—multi-sensory, narrative-driven, intellectually ambitious. They are extraordinary experiences. But they also raise a question: how long can experience outrun appetite? At what point does the diner begin to crave not astonishment, but comfort?

Because here is the quiet truth: novelty has a short shelf life. What dazzles today can feel dated tomorrow. Entire categories of restaurants have risen meteorically—built on virality, on a signature plating style, on a singular "moment"—only to fade just as quickly when the next aesthetic arrives. We have all seen dining rooms that were impossible to book one year and eerily available the next.

Even some of the most talked-about spaces today—those built on spectacle, maximalism, or hyper-curated narratives—run the risk of becoming self-referential. The plating becomes predictable in its unpredictability. The experience becomes rehearsed. The very thing that once felt revolutionary begins to feel like repetition. And when that happens, the diner doesn't just lose interest—they lose trust.

This is where the conversation about flavour becomes essential. Because flavour is not a trend; it is memory. It is cultural inheritance. It is the only dimension of food that deepens over time rather than dating itself. A perfectly made dal, a deeply reduced stock, a patiently fermented batter—these do not go out of style because they are rooted in something older than fashion: they are rooted in human satisfaction.